

opera, *L'Heure espagnole*, and later by the ballet *Daphnis et Chloé*. The period between 1905 and the outbreak of World War I was, by Ravel's slow and meticulous standards, a productive one, and established him as a major composer in France and abroad. But by 1913 his rate of production slowed even more: he wrote almost nothing during the war and its aftermath. When the war started, his application to join the French Air Force was turned down because of his age (he was approaching 40 years old) and health. In 1915, however, he was accepted by the army as a driver, supplying munitions to the front.

The conditions had a terrible effect on his already fragile health—he suffered dysentery and frostbite, and was deeply affected by the horrors of war. His woes increased when his mother died in 1917. But he completed the Neo-Baroque piano suite *Le Tombeau de Couperin* (The Tomb of Couperin) during this time, its separate movements each honoring a friend lost in war. The piece evoked the music of the Baroque composer François Couperin (1668–1733).

Ravel emerged from war exhausted and depressed, and only slowly resumed work. In contrast to his early career, Ravel was now revered by the musical establishment as the heir to Debussy, and as the foremost French composer. But this was a very different era, dominated by new ideas from younger composers such as the group known as Les Six, who saw Ravel's music as outdated. As always, though, he was oblivious to criticism and, after completing the richly Romantic *La Valse* (The Waltz) in 1920, he began a second phase of composing, developing a slightly more modern style influenced by the atonality of